

My name is Erick Bellomy Jr. and my dad was shot and killed on October 12, 2017 by a family member in his own home that I lived in. He was the 101st person to be killed in a record breaking year for homicides. When I heard the devastating news that something terrible happened at home, I had to stop everything that I was doing and I rushed to my 70 year old grandmas house to pick her up.

We go to my dads house where there's yellow tape everywhere and what seems to be about 2 dozen police cars on my street with various crime scene units.

We wait outside of the police tape for two hours as we watch the police and investigators enter and leave my dads house as his body was laying at the front door. At this time we had no idea what had happened and no one was giving us information on the scene.

That's when a Crisis Intervention Officer walked up to me and my grandma and said, "We're so sorry, but Erick Bellomy Sr was murdered inside of his home and his time of death is 1:20am and that my Aunt had witnessed the shooting"

Right then, as I was holding onto my grandma I felt her whole body lose strength and we both start crying. As I'm trying to stay strong, hold composure, and be there for my grandma - my dads lifeless body was laying on a cold floor in his front room door because someone who wasn't allowed to have a gun shot and killed him during a robbery attempt.

My dad wasn't a criminal, he wasn't violent and he was disabled due to a neck injury. There was no way for him to protect himself in this situation.

Me, being a 22 year old who has never had a significant loss before had to plan a whole funeral for my dad. I picked out a beautiful baby blue casket and flowers; which was the same color as his eyes and his all time favorite color. We had to pick out his obituary, music, plot and headstone all within a 2 week period

After his death all while grieving his loss I had to face hundreds of people at his funeral who were completely devastated, shocked and they had no idea how to even approach our family because of the circumstances and how distraught our family was after seeing my dad lay in his casket ready to be buried forever. This pain has continued to this day. There's not a day that goes by where I don't think of him. I miss him more and more everyday and everything, and when I say everything.... i mean everything reminds me of him. He was a great man, son and most importantly he was a great father who would do anything for anyone if they needed it.

The reason I'm sharing my story is because there are ever lasting effects to families who are impacted by gun violence. It's a devastating loss that can't be explained. But, I can explain how he died.

1 Bullet entered by dad's chest, nicked his heart and hit his spinal cord which made him instantly go down to the ground and he was dead within seconds... there was no time to save him, there was no time for us to say our final goodbyes and there was no time for me to grow and have a real father son relationship with him and to make him proud like every other son has wanted. Because of a heartless person with a stolen gun I'll never be able to experience this.

This bill will put more people at risk to be shot and killed without reason. In Florida, a similar law was linked to a 32 percent increase in firearm homicides; and homicides considered justifiable tripled.

Why do we need a bill like this? Why do we want to give people the opportunity to get away with murder just like George Zimmerman did when he killed Trayvon Martin? Is that True Justice?

This bill will give people an excuse to pull a trigger and then say that they were defending themselves and the person who is now dead would not be able to tell their side of the story. leaving families without answers. What kind of justice is that? None in my opinion. Is that what our system is now becoming? Do we really need a Stand Your Ground bill with all of these current shootings happening in cities across the nation, in schools, hospitals, movie theatres, malls and in people's own homes?

Please, consider the victims in shootings around the nation especially the ones that has happened in Florida, where a stand your ground law is in place... such as the cases of 17 year old Trayvon Martin who was killed because of racial profiling;.....

When retired police captain Curtis Reeves shot and killed Chad Oulson in his chest because Oulson threw a bag of popcorn at him because of an altercation regarding a cell phone being on;.....

When Nick Julian shot unarmed Carlos Garcia during an altercation over music in a car being too loud;.....

and most recently when 28 year old Markeis McGlockton was shot and killed after a parking lot altercation in front of his wife and 2 small children.

In Closing,

Yearly 125 thousand people in America are shot in murders, assaults, suicides & suicide attempts, unintentional shootings, or by police intervention. 35 thousand people die from gun violence while

90 thousand people survive their gun injuries. Please as you make your decisions to pass this bill, think of the families and victims in these incidents. I ask that you please oppose this bill for our children's sake. Our Future and for all victims of gun violence. Thank you for your time.